According to Yijing, ‘ghee, oil, milk, and cream’ are ubiquitous, as are cereal cakes, rice and fruit like mangoes and bananas. Also common, he writes, are sweet melons, sugar cane, tubers, mustard leaves and mustard oil. Xuanzang adds to this list ginger, jackfruit, pomegranates, sweet oranges and ‘sugar-candy’, and notes that fish, mutton, gazelle and deer are eaten. He notices alcohol use by Kshatriyas and Vaishayas, not Brahmins and Buddhists. Curiously, Yijing observes that Indians ‘do not eat any kind of onions’ and associate them with causing tummy aches, diseases and bodily weakness. If ‘anyone uses [onions and garlic] for food,’ writes Xuanzang, ‘they are expelled beyond the walls of the town’, along with the other dietary misfits, ‘despised and scorned’ for consuming the wrong kinds of meat: ox, pig, ass, dog, monkey and ‘all the hairy kind’. Faxian, nearly 300 years before Yijing, described a similar social reality when he wrote,

> Throughout the whole country the people do not . . . eat onions or garlic. The only exception is that of the Chandalas. That is the name for those who are (held to be) wicked men, and live apart from others. When they enter the gate of a city or a market-place, they strike a piece of wood to make themselves known, so that men know and avoid them, and do not come into contact with them . . . Only the Chandalas are fishermen and hunters, and sell flesh meat.[24]

Yijing takes pride in the state of healing and medical science in China and considers India way behind. Some Indian home remedies puzzle him, such as foregoing food and water for days during illnesses; other practices disgust him. In some places, he writes, ‘a low custom has long been prevalent, i.e., whenever a sickness arises, people use urine and feces as medicaments, sometimes the dung of pigs or cats, which is put on a plate or kept in a jar’. Yijing denounces it as ‘the worst of impure filth’. He knows that *Vinaya Pitaka* itself sanctions ‘the dung of a calf and urine of a cow’ as medicines, at least for the skin, but even his piety can’t accept this scriptural folly; he creatively tries to discredit it by saying that only a few schools of Buddhism believe in it.

When a person dies, writes Xuanzang, his friends and relatives ‘strike their heads and beat their breasts’. Those who attend a funeral are deemed unclean, and must ‘bathe outside the town and then enter their homes’. He also describes a haunting practice that seems a lot like euthanasia (though one wonders how much of it was entirely voluntary).